

This summary outlines the key discussions and strategic objectives from the **Seven Sisters Music Initiative** catchup held on 26 February 2026.

Vision and Strategic Objectives

The initiative aims to establish a **National Music Conservatoire** in India, with primary hubs in Assam, Shillong, and Delhi.

- **The "IIT Model":** The project is inspired by the IIT phenomenon, aiming to create a centre of excellence for music education in India.
- **Cultural Bridge:** A core goal is to codify Indian regional music (including the legacy of Zubeen Garg and Bihu music) into Western notation to make it accessible and "translatable" for international musicians.
- **Career Ecosystem:** Beyond examinations, the initiative seeks to build a sustainable ecosystem, including a **National Orchestra and Choir**, to provide professional employment for Indian musicians within India.

Educational Framework

- **Foundational Excellence:** Teaching will span from Grade 1 to postgraduate levels, focusing on instrumentation, orchestration, and theory.
- **International Standards:** The initiative will bring teaching from institutions like **Trinity Laban** directly to India to improve local pedagogy.
- **Ethnomusicology:** Experts will work to provide a structured "grammar" to Indian folk and regional music, ensuring it becomes part of the global academic discourse.

Partnership Roles and Logistics

- **Zubeen Garg Trust:** The Trust will provide moral and artistic weight. As an NGO, the Trust will focus on sponsoring non-privileged students (e.g., 5-10 students per workshop) rather than direct profit-making activities.
- **Infrastructure:** Dr Palme Borthakur suggested **Royal Global University** as a potential local partner to provide the infrastructure for a pilot project.
- **Global Connections:** The initiative leverages Andrew Bernardi's success with similar models in Hong Kong and connections with the High Commission in London.

Key Discussion Points & Concerns

- **Practical Career Paths:** Concerns were raised regarding how this training translates into careers beyond teaching, particularly for the 80% of students who remain in India.
- **Evangelisation:** Significant effort is needed to communicate the value of this hybrid (Western/Indian) approach to local students and the government.
- **Funding Model:** A tiered approach was proposed where privileged students pay fees to cover costs, while the Trust and private sponsors fund underprivileged talent.

Immediate Next Steps

1. **Prospectus Review:** Participants to review the detailed prospectus and roadmap (Year 1–3) previously created for Mount Carmel.
2. **Pilot Workshop Planning:** Develop a specific proposal for a "Summer School" or pilot workshop in Assam for 2026, including a detailed budget and timeline.
3. **Formalisation:** Draft a **Memorandum of Understanding (MOU)** between the Zubeen Garg Trust and the Bernardi Music Group to define roles and limitations.
4. **Institutional Outreach:** Andrew Bernardi to engage with the Principal and senior management at **Trinity Laban** to formalise their support for the Indian expansion.
5. **Local Networking:** Mondweep and the Trust members to continue "evangelising" the project to local partners and potential corporate sponsors.